Vladimir Penkin

Staff Software Engineer · Backend & Full-Stack

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San Francisco, California (Open to remote)

Authorized to work in the U.S., no sponsorship required

PROFILE

Staff Software Engineer with 11 years at Rev.com, owning systems from its core editor platform and APIs to legal-AI products. Most recently tech lead for SmartDepo, an acquired legal-AI product: took it from no tests or staging environment to multiple deploys per day on Kubernetes and Terraform, integrated it into Rev's platform in 4 months, and owned LLM summarization pipelines processing ~1,000 depositions per week. Previously built Legal Transcriptions product offering on top of Rev transcriptions business.

CORE SKILLS

Programming	C#, Python, TypeScript, Ruby, Node.js
Backend	.NET / ASP.NET Core, Flask, Ruby on Rails, REST APIs
Platform Engineering	Kubernetes, Docker, Helm, Terraform, IaC, CI/CD, Prometheus, Grafana
Databases	PostgreSQL, MSSQL, MongoDB, Supabase, Snowflake, Looker
Frontend	React, Next.js, GraphQL, ProseMirror
AI/LLM	LiteLLM, scikit-learn, spaCy
Cloud & Infrastructure	AWS, Azure, Vercel, Linux
CI/CD	Jenkins, GitHub Actions, Ansible
Communication	Remote work, Cross-team communication

EXPERIENCE

Rev.com

Feb 2015 – June 2026

Rev – began as a speech-to-text, transcription and captioning platform combining ASR with a freelance marketplace; grew ~10x in revenue over this period.

Pivoted into legal AI: now an investigative-intelligence platform for 2,000+ law firms and agencies.

Staff SWE, Technical Lead (SmartDepo)

June 2025 – June 2026

SmartDepo – an AI deposition summary and analysis platform for litigators, with page/line-cited summaries, cross-witness analysis and Q&A across case testimony. Acquired by Rev in 2025. Inherited with no CI, tests, staging or secrets management, and only one engineer able to work on it.

- Re-platformed the backend from AWS Lambda to Kubernetes and Terraform, adding dev and staging environments alongside production. Rebuilt delivery on Jenkins with unit tests and versioned database migrations, going from 2 deploys per month to multiple per day.
- Owned the hierarchical LLM summarization pipelines behind SmartDepo's page/line-cited deposition summaries, routing between open-weight and commercial models via LiteLLM; processed ~1,000 depositions per week.
- Delivered Multi-Witness processing, SmartDepo's key product milestone of the year, extending the product beyond single-witness depositions to hearings, trials and arbitrations. Coordinated changes across the AI backend, web frontend, database schemas and admin tooling; shipped on deadline.
- Led SmartDepo's technical integration into Rev's platform (auth, infrastructure, observability and scaling) in 4 months with no customer downtime.
- Mentored 3 incoming engineers, plus contractors and QA through a year of heavy team turnover while sustaining delivery; owned code-review standards across SmartDepo and Rev Legal.

Staff SWE (Rev Legal)

July 2023 – June 2025

- Designed the workflow that routes a legal order through Rev's freelancer marketplace into a final legal deliverable.
- Led the launch of Legal Essentials, a new product tier, as technical lead for a team of 6 engineers, cutting turnaround from 8 business days to under 2.

- Built checkout and ordering for Rev Legal offerings, processing $2M in orders per year.
- Built the legal-transcript editor used in the freelancer workflow.

Senior SWE (Freelancer Platform & Editors) 2015 – 2022

- Led development of Rev's four core work editors in React and ProseMirror, the production tools behind Rev's human-verified transcription, captioning and subtitling.
- Scaled the editors to tens of thousands of freelancers working through millions of minutes of audio. Designed per-second autosave so freelancers virtually eliminated lost work.
- Built the ASR review editor, where freelancers correct machine-generated transcripts. This was Rev's human-in-the-loop workflow for speech recognition.
- Built the freelancer marketplace lifecycle: application and onboarding, earnings and performance dashboards, rating and quality control that processed 1k+ applicants per month.
- Contributed to the year-long, company-wide migration from .NET Framework to .NET Core, migrating 20+ of the team's services. Resulted in Linux containers, performance gains.

StaunchRobots

Medellín · 2012 – 2013

Co-founder and Tech Lead

- Built and led a distributed team of up to 7 engineers across Colombia, Brazil, Russia, Romania and the US, working from the Medellín office; recruited developers from Brazil.
- Worked full-time as a senior Rails engineer, embedded in US clients' teams (BigBinary, Verdacom, TruckingOffice).
- Trained new hires in Ruby and Rails and mentored the team on engineering problems. Ran a free Ruby course for 5 aspiring developers.

Early Career

Russia · 2007 – 2012

Self-employed / Employed

- Developed project management tool for arbel-designs.com.
- Built data crawlers and analytics pipelines at Visual Systems Research Group (VSRG).
- Developed CV application tool and file conversion service at Jobstar.se.
- Application design, maintenance and upgrade for Ruby projects at railsrescue.com.
- Built auctions platform on top of Magento e-commerce solution for bstock.com.
- Developed e-commerce websites and modules using Magento e-commerce framework, bespoke plugins for WordPress platform, Zend Framework, PHP, MySQL at oggetto.team.
- Developed admin panel and spellchecking solution for WebMail product at afterlogic.com.

EDUCATION

Southern Federal University, Taganrog, Russia – Computer Science (~Masters) 2007 – 2011

PROJECTS

- Homelab automation (shell/infra) – running a few servers at home and in the public cloud to provide self-governed services for family use. Using Proxmox, Ansible, Grafana, Prometheus, Talos Linux, Kubernetes cluster, Terraform, Tailscale, Cloudflare.
- Vscode-jump-to-alternative – a VS Code extension to jump between code and test files.
- Map to Poster – lets you create striking map posters.
- Prize winner: MyGengo API Wrapper contest for Ruby and Zend Framework.

LANGUAGES

English – Fluent · **Russian** – Native · **Spanish** – Basic